FROM THE ARCHIVES
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Business
Ready for the Fizz


READY FOR THE FIZZ

Rising sales, new brands and an image makeover that pits the frothy drink as the youth's 'new soft drink', have the industry preparing for a heady summer

- Beer has also had a more socially legitimate image makeover. "It's casual, like a soft drink," insists Pebble Street's Ashish Ahuja, who is planning an exclusive beer-drinkers club in Delhi like Bangalore's BAIT (Beer Drinkers Association of Information Technology) Club that once had Pradeep Kar (Microland) and Nandan Nilekani (Infosys) as members
- Some, like V. Harinath, a 24-year-old software engineer in India's first beer city Bangalore, even calls beer a "health drink". There are other sobriquets: aperitif, warm-up liquid, social ice-breaker, thirst quencher...
- The "mild, alcoholic beverage, not alcohol", as Zinia Lawyer, president of the All India Brewers' Association (AIBA), calls it, is in for a heady summer

–Methil Renuka

DID YOU KNOW?

D'yavol, a Scotch whisky brand co-owned by Bollywood superstar Shah Rukh Khan and his son Aryan, was among the gold medallists at the 2024 New York World Spirits Competition

191.1 MILLION

No. of cases of beer United Breweries sold in FY24. Formerly the jewel in Vijay Mallya's spirits empire but now controlled by Dutch MNC Heineken NV, India's biggest brewer has over 50% market share

ANOTHER ROUND?

» Kingfisher helped position beer as a youthful, fun, aspirational beverage in the '90s, led to a boom in domestic breweries

» India's liquor brands have upped their game, producing world-class ales, whiskies and gins of late

that originated from India's first pub city, Bangalore. But beer, or lager, wasn't the drink of choice in a country where hard liquor, especially whisky, ruled the roost. That said, if Kingfisher was looking for a brand ambassador to carve up a market for itself, it couldn't have asked for a better one than bossman Mallya who became synonymous with the brand's 'King of Good Times' catchphrase.

"Beer started coming into prominence in the mid-1990s," recalls Shekhar Ramamurthy, who spent 21 years at United Breweries, including five years as managing director, before moving on to his current role as executive deputy chairman at Mumbai-headquartered Allied Blenders & Distillers Pvt. Ltd. It was a period when the transformative effect of the economic liberalisation of 1991 was beginning to show. "Brand Kingfisher rode on this," says Ramamurthy. "It's the one brand that you can find in a shack in Goa and in a bar at the Taj or Marriott."

That story of transformation hasn't stopped for the Indian liquor industry. Take Indian-made whiskies, for instance—these were typically locally-distilled spirits (usually from molasses) blended with Scotch whiskey. However, by the mid-2000s, the late Neelakanta Rao R. Jagdale from Amrut Distilleries was exporting to Europe single malt whiskies distilled in Bengaluru, defying the warmer climes at home that made maturing whiskey much more difficult. When British critic Jim Murray rated one of these, called Amrut Fusion, the third best whiskey in the world in his 2010 *Whisky Bible*, it catapulted Rao into instant fame and pioneered a new wave of premium spirits.



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Executive deputy chairman, Allied Blenders & Distillers Pvt. Ltd

Now, a slew of Indian-made single malts such as Paul John, Rampur and Indri hold their own in a global market of top-notch whiskies. Add to that craft gins—think Hapusa, Samsara and Jaisalmer—which are blazing a new trail, experimenting with Indian junipers and botanicals in true start-up fervour. It's a similar frenzy that has frothed up India's craft beer industry over the past decade with microbreweries mushrooming in the country's big cities, satiating a thirst for anything from India Pale Ale to German-style wheat beers. ■